SMACCs (Erasmus Mundus, Smart Cities and Communities): Application Strategy

Verified facts, fit analysis, motivation letter, interview strategy. Scholarship deadline 1 Feb 2027

Evidence: smaccs.eu cannot be opened from this machine (it is outside the session's allowed network). Every SMACCs fact below is **E2**: from the official smaccs.eu pages as returned by search on 8 Nov 2026. **Before submitting, open each linked page in your browser and confirm it.**

Label: B (possible, needs evidence), up from C:

- Work experience is scored.
- English can be shown by prior instruction in English.
- An ICT specialisation exists.
- Ethiopia qualifies for both scholarship categories.

1. Verified facts

Question	Answer	Source (E2)
Programme	2-year joint MSc, 120 ECTS; 3 semesters of courses + a thesis semester; at least one Summer School and one Winter School	smaccs.eu/the-programme/programme-structure
Universities and paths	Semesters 1 and 3: **University of Vaasa (Finland)** and **University of the Basque Country UPV/EHU, Bilbao (Spain)**, order depending on the path. Semester 2: **University of Mons (Belgium)** or **International Hellenic University, Thessaloniki (Greece)**. You choose a preferred path + two alternatives **when you apply**	…/programme-structure/mobility
Specialisations	Sustainable Urban Planning, Energy and Transport (UMONS); **Information and Communication Technologies (IHU)**; Energy Efficiency in Buildings (UPV/EHU); Smart Grid Solutions (UWASA). You earn the specialisation where you complete 60 ECTS (one semester + thesis)	…/programme-structure
Eligibility	Bachelor's in engineering or science; other degrees reviewed case by case. **English proven by a standardised test or by prior instruction in English**	smaccs.eu/faq, /admissions/admission-criteria
Selection	Ranked by a **global merit score** built from degree content, study success, motivation letter, references (2, at least 1 academic), **work experience**, R&D experience/publications, English proficiency. Applicants above a minimum threshold are admissible (at least as self-funded)	/admissions/admission-criteria, /faq
Interview	For the best admissible applicants, **7–18 April 2027**	/admissions/deadlines

Question	Answer	Source (E2)
Scholarships	**95** Erasmus Mundus scholarships across four intakes (Sept 2024, 2025, 2026, 2027). The per-intake number is not published. **35** of the 95 are “Heading 6” additional scholarships for students from third countries not associated to the programme: 31 funded by NDICI–Global Europe, 4 by IPA III	/practical/scholarships
Which categories include Ethiopia	**Regular EMJM scholarships** (open to all nationalities) **and** the **NDICI-funded Heading 6 scholarships** (third countries not associated to the programme). IPA III (4 places) is for pre-accession countries, not Ethiopia. No regional sub-quota is published	/practical/scholarships (inference from the categories: confirm by e-mail if you want certainty)
Nationality limit	No more than **10%** of all scholarships awarded during the project may go to one nationality	/practical/scholarships
Amount	**€1,400 per month for up to 24 months + tuition waived**	/admissions/fees, student agreement
Insurance	Consortium pays health insurance (scholarship and self-funded students)	/faq
Not covered	Mobility travel and accommodation; Summer/Winter School travel and lodging; visa and residence-permit fees; graduation costs; university language courses. These must come out of the €1,400 a month	/admissions/fees, student agreement
Self-funded tuition	€8,000 per year (€16,000 in total) for third-country students	/admissions/fees
Deadlines	**Scholarship applicants: 1 Feb 2027.** Self-funded: 30 Apr 2027 (visa needed) / 8 Jun 2027. Scholarship results by **9 May 2027**	/admissions/deadlines
Cohort size	At most 40 students	/faq

2. Is your profile suitable? Honest fit analysis

Path to choose:

- **ICT specialisation:** Semester 2 at IHU, Thessaloniki, with the thesis at IHU.
- **Alternatives:** paths whose Semester 2 is at Mons, or a thesis at Vaasa (Smart Grid Solutions, if its monitoring and data side suits you).

Smart-city theme	Genuine link to your work (only if confirmed)	What you must not claim
Digital infrastructure	You operate Linux servers, networks and deployment pipelines for payment services	Designing city-wide networks
Smart urban services	Digital payments are city services: merchants, schools, transport fares, utility bills. School-fee payments are part of SantimPay’s services	Running smart-city projects
Intelligent systems	Monitoring and alerting on live services; interest in anomaly detection	AI expertise (you have one introductory AI course, grade B)

Smart-city theme	Genuine link to your work (only if confirmed)	What you must not claim
Cybersecurity	Security controls at Kifiya (IAM/MFA, WAF, PAM/DAM: only those you configured yourself); Computer Security course (B)	Security research
Data-driven public services	Transaction and monitoring data that show how a service is used and when it fails	Public-sector data projects
Technology infrastructure	Reliability, automation and incident response	–
Sustainable digital transformation	Ethiopia's move from cash to digital payments; energy cost of running infrastructure	Energy-engineering knowledge

Weaknesses:

- Grades (study success) and the lack of R&D experience or publications.

Strengths:

- Relevant degree content (CS → ICT track).
- Work experience on live public-facing digital services.
- An English-taught degree.

3. Motivation letter (draft, about 550 words; rewrite in your own voice)

Subject: Application to the Erasmus Mundus Joint Master in Smart Cities and Communities (SMACCs), September 2027, ICT specialisation

Dear SMACCs Selection Committee,

In Addis Ababa, one of Africa's fastest-growing cities, more and more everyday transactions now pass through digital systems: a shopkeeper accepting a QR payment, a parent paying school fees from a phone, a bank settling payments for thousands of merchants. Since [⏳ year] I have worked on the infrastructure behind such services at SantimPay, a payments company that runs POS, QR, school-payment and payment-gateway services with Ethiopian banks [⏳ your exact role]. My work keeps these services running: I [⏳ two verified duties]. When they fail, the effect is immediately visible in the city: a merchant cannot sell, a family cannot pay.

This experience convinced me that a smart city is first of all reliable, secure digital infrastructure that people can trust, and that data from these systems can make urban services better. I want to learn how to design such infrastructure for whole communities, and how to connect it to energy, mobility and public services. That is why I am applying to SMACCs, and to its Information and Communication Technologies specialisation in particular.

Academic preparation. I hold a BSc in Computer Science from Debre Tabor University (2022), taught in English. My cumulative GPA is 2.62/4.00. My results improved strongly as I moved into core computing subjects: my final year was my best (3.20 by my calculation from the transcript), with A− in Advanced Programming, Compiler Design, Complexity Theory and both parts of my final-year project ([⏳ title]). I also studied Data Communication and Computer Networks, Wireless and Mobile Computing (B+), Introduction to Distributed Systems, Computer Security and Introduction to Artificial Intelligence.

Professional experience. [⏳ Two or three sentences from the HR letters: titles, years, responsibilities.] [⏳ One concrete example: an incident, an automation or a rollout, with a real result.] [⏳ If true: one sentence on security work at Kifiya.]

Why SMACCs. Three things attract me:

1. The mobility path lets me study smart-grid and ICT perspectives in Finland, Spain and Greece, which matches the interdisciplinary nature of the problems I see at home.
2. The ICT specialisation at the International Hellenic University would give me the networking, IoT and data-platform depth that my operational work lacks.

3. Projects with industry and the Summer and Winter Schools would train me to work in international teams on real urban problems.

I would choose the path [⏳ exact path name from the application form] with my thesis at IHU, and as a thesis direction I would like to explore [⏳ e.g. resilient and secure data platforms for city payment and mobility services in fast-growing African cities].

After SMACCs. I intend to return to Ethiopia and work on the digital infrastructure of urban services, [⏳ e.g. payment and data platforms for city transport, utilities or schools], helping to make them reliable, secure and inclusive. I would also share what I learn with engineers and students at home [⏳ only a real plan].

Thank you for considering my application.

Yours sincerely, [Passport name]

4. Interview strategy (7–18 April 2027, if invited)

Prepare a 3-minute self-presentation:

1. Degree → final-year improvement
2. Payment infrastructure → one real result
3. Why SMACCs + the ICT path
4. Thesis direction
5. Plan after graduation

Likely question	Outline (use real facts)
Why smart cities, given that you work in fintech?	Payments are an urban service; reliability, security and data are the core of smart-city platforms
Why the ICT specialisation and this path?	Networks, IoT and data platforms; link each semester's location to what you want to learn
What do you know about smart-city technology?	IoT sensing → networks → data platforms → services; the security and privacy risks; energy use. Read 2–3 recent smart-city case studies before April
Your grades are modest. Why should we rank you?	Upward trend, relevant A− courses, real responsibility for live services
A technical problem you solved	One incident STAR story
Teamwork across cultures	A real example with partner banks or colleagues
Can you handle three countries in two years?	Practical answers: budget from the €1,400 a month, visas, adaptability
Thesis idea	A specific, modest question; ask the panel which professor works on it

Preparation:

- 2 mock interviews with me (recorded).
- Read the IHU ICT specialisation course list once it is visible on smaccs.eu.

5. Documents and timeline

Documents to confirm on smaccs.eu → Admissions → Instructions (E2):

- online application, with path choice + 2 alternatives
- CV
- transcripts and diploma
- motivation letter
- **2 reference letters (at least 1 academic)**
- English proof (test, or evidence that your degree was taught in English)
- passport

By	Action
20 Nov	Read the official Instructions and Application pages in your browser; note any upload limits
15 Jan	Two reference letters received (DTU supervisor + SantimPay manager)
20 Jan	Letter and CV final (`06_FINAL_CV/CV_Europe_Academic.docx`)
25 Jan	**Submit** (deadline 1 Feb 2027)
7–18 Apr	Interview, if invited
9 May	Scholarship results

Erasmus Mundus limit: at most 3 Erasmus Mundus applications in one intake. Your set is **AISS + SMACCs + EDISS** (EDISS only if you decide its low probability is worth one day).